CORE FALSE BELIEF #17 · RULES I LIVE BY

"I must be perfect."

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Where it often comes from

Perfectionism often grows in homes where love or approval seemed to depend on performance, where mistakes were criticized harshly, or where a child tried to keep chaos at bay by being "good." Schools, sports, workplaces, and even churches can reward it. Perfectionism can look like high standards, but underneath is often fear of failure, rejection, or shame.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture teaches that all have sinned and fall short, and that we are made right with God freely by His grace, not by being flawless. The Lord has compassion on His children, because He knows how we are formed and remembers that we are dust. Paul was confident that God, who began a good work in believers, will complete it. Doing our best is good; demanding perfection of ourselves is a burden God never placed on us. Jesus invites us to take His yoke, which is easy and light.

> *"As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him. For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust"* (Psalm 103:13–14).

Also see

> "For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified freely by His grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus" (Romans 3:23–24).

> "Being confident of this, that He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus" (Philippians 1:6).

> "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me" (2 Corinthians 12:9).

> "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me; for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For My yoke is easy and My burden is light" (Matthew 11:28–30).

Common self-statements

- If it isn't perfect, it's a failure.
- I can't let anyone see my flaws.
- I have to do it all myself so it's done right.
- Good enough isn't good enough.
- If I make a mistake, people will think less of me.
- I should be able to do better.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing anything less than perfect as total failure.
- Should statements: Living by rigid rules about how I must perform.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking what I did well because of one flaw.
- Mind reading: Assuming others judge me harshly for small mistakes.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that I had to be perfect?
- What am I afraid will happen if I am not perfect?
- Do I hold others to the same standard I hold myself?
- What does God expect of me, and what does His grace provide?
- What has perfectionism cost me?
- What would "good enough" look like in one area this week?

Truth summary

> I want to do things well, and that is good. But I am human, and God knows I am made of dust. He accepts me by grace, not by flawless performance. I can do my best, make mistakes, and rest in His grace.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grace
- Thinking, Unhealthy
- Humility
- Tired
- Self-Esteem, Low

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Grace Wins — Matthew West
Grace offers a new beginning rather than defining a person by failure.

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I must be perfect"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must be perfect." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me I had to be perfect?
- ☐ What am I afraid will happen if I'm not?
- ☐ Do I hold others to the same standard?
- ☐ What does God's grace provide?
- ☐ What has perfectionism cost me?
- ☐ What would good enough look like?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God knows I am dust and has compassion on me.
- ☐ I am made right by grace, not perfection.
- ☐ God will finish the work He started in me.
- ☐ Good enough is often good enough.
- ☐ Mistakes are part of being human.
- ☐ Jesus' yoke is easy and light.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Psalm 103:13–14**
  "As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him. For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust."
- ☐ **Romans 3:23–24**
  "For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified freely by His grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."
- ☐ **Philippians 1:6**
  "Being confident of this, that He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Good enough today: Each day, write one thing you allowed to be "good enough" and what happened as a result.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 103:13–14 becomes: "Linda can write: "God knows how I am made. He has compassion on me when I fall short.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- ☐ Do something imperfectly on purpose. Choose one low-stakes task, such as sending an email without rereading it three times, and let it be good enough.
- ☐ Count the cost. Write what perfectionism has cost you in time, rest, relationships, or joy.
- ☐ Share a flaw. Tell one trusted person about a mistake you made this week. Notice how they respond.
- ☐ Set a time limit. Give a task a set amount of time, and stop when the time is up.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must be perfect": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Something I let be good enough
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must be perfect.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I have tried so hard to be perfect, and I am tired. Thank You that You know I am dust and that Your grace covers me. Help me do my best, accept my limits, and rest in Your love. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.